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2027 CYCLE

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CUET UG

Political Science

Democratic Upsurge and Coalition Politics

Official Syllabus · Politics in India Since Independence · Class 12 · CUET UG 2027 Cycle Notes

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Syllabus Alignment

Sub-topic	Official syllabus pointer (NTA CUET(UG) Political Science syllabus 2026, the current 2027 baseline — Politics in India Since Independence)	Skills the questions test
The 1990s Transition	Participatory upsurge in 1990s. End of the Congress System and beginning of the coalition era.	Identifying the five structural shifts: 1989 election, Mandal quota, 1991 economic reforms, Ayodhya dispute, Rajiv Gandhi assassination.
Rise of the JD and the BJP	Rise of the Janata Dal and the Bharatiya Janata Party; emergence of multi-party competitive politics.	Tracing the 1988 Janata Dal formation, V.P. Singh's anti-corruption platform, and the ideological paradox of outside support.
Mandal Politics & OBCs	Mandal Commission recommendations, implementation in 1990, anti-reservation protests, and social justice assertion.	Recalling B.P. Mandal, Article 340, 27% quota, Indra Sawhney (1992) creamy layer doctrine and 50% reservation ceiling.
UF & NDA Governments	United Front (1996–1998) and National Democratic Alliance (1998–2004) governments; coalition management.	Sequencing Prime Ministers (Deve Gowda, Gujral, Vajpayee); Gujral Doctrine; Common Minimum Programme; Pokhran-II (1998).
UPA & NDA III/ IV Regimes	Elections 2004–2019, UPA government (2004–2014), and addition of dominant NDA government (2014–2019+).	Understanding rights-based legislation (RTI, MGNREGA), the 2014/2019 single-party majorities within NDA, and Yogendra Yadav's Three Democratic Upsurges.

CUET UG Exam Strategy — Chapter 7 Focus

- **Pattern:** 50 Multiple Choice Questions (attempt any 40) in 60 minutes.
- **Marking:** +5 marks for correct choice, −1 mark negative deduction for incorrect choice.
- **High-Yield Angles:** Chronological sequencing of Prime Ministers (1989–2024), details of the Mandal Commission report vs Indra Sawhney judgment, outside-support paradoxes, and the characteristics of the three democratic upsurges.

1. The Historical Transition of the 1990s

The late 1980s and early 1990s witnessed five major structural developments that permanently ended single-party hegemony and created a pluralistic, multi-party coalition order.

The Five Crucial Developments

- **End of Congress Dominance (1989):**
  - The ninth general election in 1989 defeated the Rajiv Gandhi-led Congress, reducing it to 197 seats.
  - Although Congress remained the single largest party, it chose to sit in the opposition.
  - This marked the demise of what political scientist Rajni Kothari called the **"Congress System"**, ushering in twenty-five years of coalition governments at the Centre.
- **The Mandal Issue and OBC Mobilization (1990):**
  - In August 1990, the National Front government under Prime Minister V.P. Singh implemented the Mandal Commission recommendation of a 27% reservation for Other Backward Classes (OBCs) in Central government employment.
  - This sparked mass student agitations in northern cities and permanently organized the backward castes into potent regional electoral forces.
- **Structural Economic Reforms (1991):**
  - India faced a catastrophic balance of payments crisis in mid-1991, with foreign exchange reserves depleted to barely two weeks of imports.
  - Prime Minister P.V. Narasimha Rao and Finance Minister Dr. Manmohan Singh launched structural adjustment programs known as **LPG (Liberalisation, Privatisation, and Globalisation)**.
  - This shifted the state from an interventionist mixed economy toward market-oriented growth.
- **Ayodhya Dispute and Rise of the BJP:**
  - The unlocking of the Babri structure in 1986, followed by L.K. Advani's Rath Yatra in 1990 and the demolition of the structure on 6 December 1992, brought Hindutva and cultural nationalism to national centerstage.
  - The BJP steadily increased its Lok Sabha presence: 2 seats in 1984, 85 in 1989, 120 in 1991, and 161 in 1996, emerging as the principal rival pole to the Congress.
- **Assassination of Rajiv Gandhi (May 1991):**
  - While campaigning in Sriperumbudur (Tamil Nadu) during the 1991 election, former Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi was assassinated by an LTTE suicide bomber.

- In the subsequent sympathy wave, Congress emerged as the single largest party (244 seats) and formed a stable minority government under P.V. Narasimha Rao (1991–1996).

2. The Rise of Janata Dal and the National Front (1989–1990)

The 1989 election brought forth an unprecedented political experiment in multi-party coalition building.

Formation of the Janata Dal

- **Origins:** Formed in October 1988 under the leadership of **Vishwanath Pratap Singh (V.P. Singh)**, former Finance and Defence Minister who resigned from the Rajiv Gandhi cabinet over defense procurement corruption.
- **Merger of Factions:** Brought together the Jan Morcha, Lok Dal, and major factions of the Janata Party and Congress (S).
- **Anti-Corruption Crusade:** V.P. Singh campaigned aggressively on transparency, highlighting allegations of kickbacks paid by Swedish weapons manufacturer AB Bofors in the sale of 155mm howitzer guns to the Indian Army.

The National Front Government (1989–1990)

- **Alliance Partners:** Janata Dal formed a broader pre-poll alliance called the **National Front**, joining regional parties including the Telugu Desam Party (TDP), Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), and Asom Gana Parishad (AGP), with N.T. Rama Rao as Chairman and V.P. Singh as Convener.
- **The Paradox of Outside Support:**
  - The National Front won 143 seats and could not form a government independently.
  - It was supported from the outside by two ideological adversaries: the **Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)** and the **Left Front**.
  - Neither the BJP nor the Left joined the ministry, creating a delicate balancing act.
- **Fall of the National Front (November 1990):**
  - In September 1990, BJP President L.K. Advani launched a nationwide Rath Yatra from Somnath to Ayodhya.
  - When the Bihar state government led by Chief Minister Lalu Prasad Yadav arrested Advani in Samastipur, the BJP withdrew outside support.
  - V.P. Singh lost a vote of confidence in the Lok Sabha on 7 November 1990, ending his 11-month tenure.

Chandra Shekhar Interim Government (1990–1991)

- Chandra Shekhar broke away from the Janata Dal with 64 MPs to form the **Samajwadi Janata Party (Rashtriya)**.
- He was sworn in as Prime Minister with outside parliamentary backing from the 197-member Congress party.
- In March 1991, the Congress pulled down the government over allegations that two Haryana police constables were spying on Rajiv Gandhi's residence, necessitating fresh elections.

3. The Mandal Commission and Other Backward Classes (OBC)

The political empowerment of Other Backward Classes (OBCs) reshaped the social base of Indian parliamentary democracy.

Constitutional Origins and Prior Commissions

- **Constitutional Mandate (Article 340):** Authorizes the President to appoint a commission to investigate the conditions of socially and educationally backward classes.
- **First Backward Classes Commission (1953):** Chaired by **Kaka Kalelkar**; submitted its report in 1955 listing 2,399 backward castes. However, the Central government shelved the report due to lack of objective socio-economic criteria.

The Second Backward Classes Commission (Mandal Commission)

- **Appointment (1978):** Appointed by the Morarji Desai Janata Party government in December 1978 under the chairmanship of **Bindeshwari Prasad Mandal (B.P. Mandal)**, former Chief Minister of Bihar.
- **Findings & Demographic Assessment:**
  - Identified 3,743 castes and communities as socially and educationally backward.
  - Estimated that Other Backward Classes constituted approximately **52% of India's total population** (excluding Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes).
- **Core Recommendations (Submitted December 1980):**
  - **27% Reservation:** Recommended a 27% quota for OBCs in all central government civilian jobs, public sector undertakings, and higher educational institutions.
  - **Rationale for 27%:** The existing SC/ST reservations totaled 22.5%. To prevent total reservations from exceeding 50%, the OBC quota was capped at 27%.
  - **Land Reforms:** Recommended structural agrarian reforms to liberate backward-caste agricultural tenants from feudal land control.

Implementation and the Indra Sawhney Judgment (1992)

- **Announcement (7 August 1990):** V.P. Singh announced executive implementation of the 27% central job quota in Parliament, leading to months of intense student strikes and self-immolations across north India.
- **Supreme Court Verdict (Indra Sawhney vs Union of India, November 1992):**
  - A historic 9-judge constitutional bench ruled 6:3 to **uphold the constitutional validity** of the 27% OBC reservation.
  - **Creamy Layer Exclusion:** Mandated that economically affluent and socially advanced individuals among OBCs must be excluded from quota benefits.
  - **50% Strict Cap:** Stated that total reservations under Article 16(4) must not exceed 50% in any given year, barring extraordinary regional exceptions.
  - **No Quotas in Promotions:** Prohibited reservations in promotional posts (later modified for SC/STs by constitutional amendments).

Definition: The Concept of 'Creamy Layer'

The Supreme Court established that reservation is a remedial tool against entrenched social and educational discrimination, not a poverty-alleviation program. Therefore, children of constitutional dignitaries, Class-I civil servants, and high-income professionals among OBCs are categorised as the **creamy layer** and ineligible for quota benefits.

4. United Front Governments (1996–1998)

The eleventh general election in 1996 produced a fractured Parliament, highlighting the decisive role of state-level regional leadership.

1996 Verdict and Vajpayee's 13-Day Stint

- **BJP Single Largest Party:** Won 161 seats; Congress dropped to 140 seats.
- **Vajpayee's Resignation:** President Shankar Dayal Sharma invited Atal Bihari Vajpayee to form the government. Unable to rally allies to reach the 272-seat majority mark, Vajpayee resigned on the floor of the Lok Sabha after just 13 days in office.

Formation of the United Front

- **Thirteen-Party Coalition:** Regional parties (TDP, DMK, AGP, Samajwadi Party, Janata Dal, Tamil Maanila Congress) banded together under the banner of the **United Front (UF)**.
- **Outside Support:** Congress (140 seats) and the Communist Party of India (Marxist) supported the United Front from the outside, while the Communist Party of India (CPI) joined the cabinet.
- **Leadership Succession:**
  - **H.D. Deve Gowda (June 1996 – April 1997):** Chief Minister of Karnataka chosen as consensus Prime Minister. Dismissed when Congress President Sitaram Kesri withdrew support.
  - **Inder Kumar Gujral (April 1997 – March 1998):** Former diplomat and external affairs minister; author of the **Gujral Doctrine**. Fell when Congress demanded the expulsion of DMK ministers after the Jain Commission interim report linked DMK to LTTE operatives.

The Gujral Doctrine — Five Fundamental Principles

1. **Unilateral Goodwill:** With immediate neighbours (Bangladesh, Bhutan, Maldives, Nepal, Sri Lanka), India does not ask for reciprocity, but gives what it can in good faith.
2. **Territorial Integrity:** No South Asian territory should be used against the security interests of another.
3. **Non-Interference:** Strict non-interference in the internal affairs of neighboring states.
4. **Sovereign Respect:** Respect for the sovereignty and territorial integrity of all nations.
5. **Bilateral Resolution:** Peaceful settlement of all disputes through bilateral negotiations.

5. The National Democratic Alliance (NDA: 1998–2004)

The BJP recognized that it could not capture national power on its own without reassuring regional allies. Under Atal Bihari Vajpayee and L.K. Advani, it constructed the National Democratic Alliance (NDA).

The Vajpayee Tenures

- **Second Term (March 1998 – April 1999 · 13 Months):**
  - Formed a coalition with AIADMK, Biju Janata Dal (BJD), Samata Party, and Shiromani Akali Dal.
  - Fallen on 17 April 1999 by a single vote (269 against 270) when J. Jayalalithaa withdrew AIADMK's 18 MPs following the refusal to dismiss the DMK government in Tamil Nadu.
- **Third Term (October 1999 – May 2004 · Full 5-Year Term):**
  - NDA won 303 seats in the 1999 mid-term elections (BJP won 182 seats).
  - **Historic Record:** Vajpayee became the **first non-Congress Prime Minister to complete a full five-year term**.

Policy Hallmarks of NDA (1998–2004)

- **Pokhran-II Nuclear Tests (11 & 13 May 1998):** Conducted five underground nuclear detonations in the Thar Desert (Operation Shakti), defying international sanctions and declaring India a nuclear-armed state.
- **Kargil Victory (May–July 1999):** Indian Armed Forces executed **Operation Vijay**, recapturing high-altitude Himalayan posts in Kargil infiltrated by Pakistani regular troops.
- **Infrastructure Revolution:** Launched the 5,846-km **Golden Quadrilateral** connecting Delhi, Mumbai, Chennai, and Kolkata, alongside the **Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana (PMGSY)** for all-weather rural connectivity.
- **Pragmatic Moderation:** To reassure regional allies, the BJP put its core contentious ideological planks (Ram Janmabhoomi temple construction, Article 370 repeal, and Uniform Civil Code) on hold, governing under the consensual **National Agenda for Governance (NAG)**.

6. The United Progressive Alliance (UPA: 2004–2014)

Defying pollsters predicting an NDA victory on the "India Shining" slogan, the 2004 general election brought the Congress back to the helm of a multi-party coalition.

UPA-I (2004–2009): The Rights-Based Architecture

- **Formation:** Congress forged the **United Progressive Alliance (UPA)** with DMK, RJD, NCP, PMK, and JMM.
- **Historic Renunciation:** Congress President Sonia Gandhi declined the prime ministership, appointing eminent economist **Dr. Manmohan Singh** as Prime Minister.

- **Left Front Leverage:** Supported from the outside by 59 Left MPs. Governance was guided by a Common Minimum Programme (CMP) monitored by the National Advisory Council (NAC).
- **Landmark Legislative Measures:**
  - **Right to Information Act (RTI, 2005):** Empowered ordinary citizens to seek certified records from public authorities within 30 days.
  - **MGNREGA (2005):** Guaranteed 100 days of wage employment per financial year to every rural household seeking unskilled manual work.
  - **Forest Rights Act (2006):** Recognized the ancestral dwelling and cultivation rights of Scheduled Tribes and traditional forest dwellers.
- **The 2008 Trust Vote:** The Left Front withdrew support in July 2008 over the Indo-US Civil Nuclear Agreement (123 Agreement). The government survived the confidence vote with outside assistance from the Samajwadi Party.

UPA-II (2009–2014)

- **2009 Re-election:** Congress won 206 seats, forming UPA-II without reliance on the Left Front.
- **Key Social Legislation:** Passed the **Right of Children to Free and Compulsory Education Act (RTE, 2009)** and the **National Food Security Act (NFSA, 2013)**.
- **Decline and Anti-Corruption Wave:** Confronted high inflation, policy paralysis, and allegations in the 2G Spectrum, Coal Block, and Commonwealth Games allocations. This sparked the massive nationwide **India Against Corruption (IAC)** movement led by Anna Hazare in 2011, paving the way for political change.

7. NDA III & IV: The Dominant Coalition Era (2014–2019+)

The 2014 general election shattered thirty years of fragmented mandates, inaugurating a new phase in India's party system.

Landmark Mandates

- **Sixteenth Lok Sabha (2014 · NDA-III):**
  - The BJP under **Narendra Modi** won 282 seats on its own (NDA secured 336 seats).
  - This was the **first single-party Lok Sabha majority in thirty years** since Rajiv Gandhi's 1984 victory.
- **Seventeenth Lok Sabha (2019 · NDA-IV):**
  - The BJP expanded its majority to 303 seats on its own (NDA reached 353 seats).
  - Re-established nationwide geographic and social expansion across northern, western, eastern, and northeastern India.

Conceptualizing the "Dominant Coalition"

- Although the BJP held a clear single-party majority in both 2014 and 2019, it accommodated pre-poll NDA allies into the Council of Ministers (e.g., LJP, Shiv Sena, Akali Dal, JD(U), Apna Dal).

- Political scientists describe this transition as the shift from a **fragmented coalition system** to a **dominant party-led coalition system**, where the BJP functions as the undisputed national pole, mirroring the centrality once enjoyed by the early Congress.

8. Yogendra Yadav's Three Democratic Upsurges

Political scientist Yogendra Yadav formulated the conceptual paradigm of **"Democratic Upsurges"** to explain how mass participation expanded and diversified in post-independence India.

Phase	Chronological Era	Social Driver & Mechanism	Political Consequence
First Upsurge	1950s – 1970s	Universal Adult Suffrage under the 1950 Constitution. Mass voter turnout of rural peasantry, illiterate citizens, and common people.	Deepening of constitutional legitimacy and electoral participation.
Second Upsurge	1980s – 1990s	Mandal Commission mobilization and Bahujan assertion. Radical political entry of Other Backward Classes (OBCs) and Dalits.	Displacement of traditional upper-caste political elites; rise of regional identity parties (SP, RJD, BSP, JD(U)).
Third Upsurge	2014 onwards	Aspirational youth, neo-middle class, and women voters. Shift toward development delivery ("Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas"), welfare digitisation, and good governance.	Consolidation of a nationwide aspirational electoral base centered on delivery of basic amenities and leadership.

9. The Emergent Political Consensus

Despite intense ideological competition, the coalition era generated four fundamental areas of broad national consensus:

- **Consensus on New Economic Policies:** Continuity in structural economic reforms, foreign investment, and privatization across Congress, United Front, and BJP administrations.
- **Acceptance of OBC Political Claims:** Universal political agreement on reservations and power-sharing for Other Backward Classes in education, administration, and political representation.
- **Federalization of Power:** Recognition that national governance requires power-sharing with regional parties, elevating state-level aspirations to federal decision-making.
- **Pragmatic Coalitions over Dogma:** Shift from inflexible ideology to governance coalitions mediated through Common Minimum Programmes and shared policy agreements.

The Whole Chapter in One Picture



Figure 1: Democratic Upsurge & Coalition Dynamics Mindmap: The 1990s transition, Janata Dal, Mandal assertion, United Front, NDA, UPA, and the Three Democratic Upsurges.

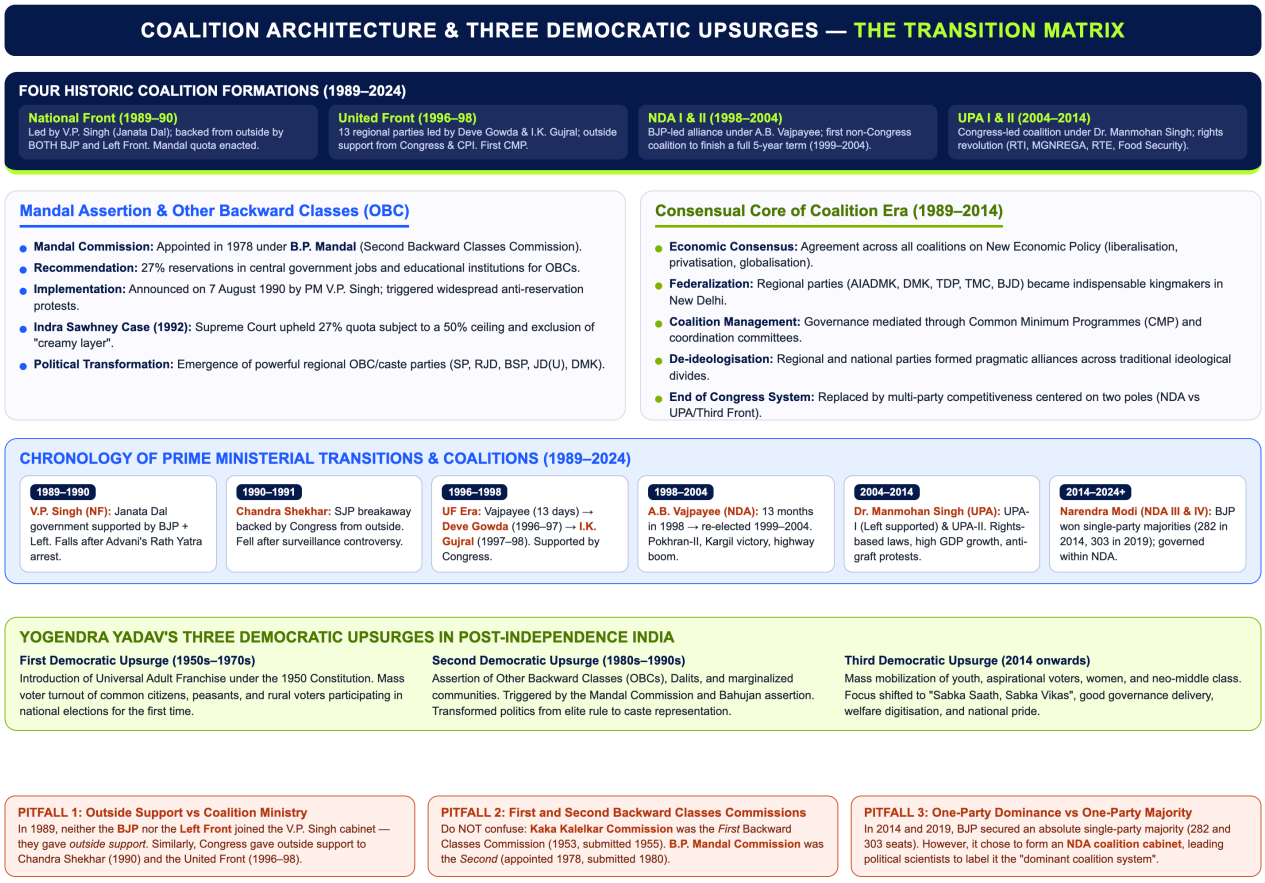


Figure 2: Coalition Architecture & Transition Matrix: The four historic coalition regimes, Mandal jurisprudence, Prime Ministerial transitions (1989–2024), and Yogendra Yadav's upsurges.

Practice Questions (Exam Pattern)

Ten questions designed in authentic CUET UG single-correct style. The official marking scheme awards +5 for each correct answer and deducts −1 for every incorrect answer.

Q1. Which year marked the formal end of the single-party 'Congress System' at the Centre, inaugurating a quarter-century of coalition governments?

(A) 1977 (B) 1984
(C) 1989 (D) 1996

Q2. The National Front government led by Prime Minister V.P. Singh in 1989 was supported from the outside by which unique ideological pairing?

(A) Congress and CPI (B) BJP and the Left Front
(C) AIADMK and DMK (D) Janata Party and Swatantra Party

Q3. Who chaired the Second Backward Classes Commission appointed by the Morarji Desai Janata Party government in 1978?

(A) Kaka Kalelkar (B) B.P. Mandal
(C) Jagjivan Ram (D) Charan Singh

Q4. In which historic verdict did the Supreme Court validate the 27% OBC reservation while imposing a 50% quota ceiling and excluding the creamy layer?

(A) Kesavananda Bharati Case (1973)
(B) Minerva Mills Case (1980)
(C) Indra Sawhney Case (1992)
(D) S.R. Bommai Case (1994)

Q5. Which Prime Minister formulated the foreign policy doctrine that India must extend non-reciprocal unilateral goodwill to smaller South Asian neighbours?

(A) P.V. Narasimha Rao
(B) H.D. Deve Gowda
(C) I.K. Gujral
(D) Atal Bihari Vajpayee

Q6. Which was the first non-Congress coalition government in post-independence India to complete a full five-year term in office?

(A) Janata Party Government (1977–1982)
(B) United Front Government (1996–2001)
(C) National Democratic Alliance (1999–2004)
(D) United Progressive Alliance (2004–2009)

Q7. According to Yogendra Yadav's framework, the 'Second Democratic Upsurge' in Indian politics was primarily marked by:

(A) The introduction of universal adult suffrage in the 1950s
(B) The electoral mobilization and assertion of Other Backward Classes (OBCs)
(C) The adoption of Liberalisation, Privatisation, and Globalisation in 1991
(D) The youth-driven aspirational voting post-2014

Q8. Which landmark rights-based act guaranteeing 100 days of rural wage employment was enacted by the UPA-I government in 2005?

(A) Right to Information Act
(B) MGNREGA
(C) Right to Education Act
(D) National Food Security Act

Q9. The minority government led by Prime Minister Chandra Shekhar in 1990–1991 came to power with the outside support of which party?

(A) Bharatiya Janata Party
(B) Left Front
(C) Indian National Congress
(D) Telugu Desam Party

Q10. In the 2014 general election, how many seats did the Bharatiya Janata Party win on its own to achieve the first single-party majority in 30 years?

(A) 272
(B) 282
(C) 303
(D) 336

Detailed Solutions

Sol. Q1. The 1989 general election ended single-party Congress dominance at the Centre; although Congress won 197 seats, it chose to sit in opposition, ushering in multi-party coalition rule.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q2. The National Front government under V.P. Singh was supported from the outside by both the right-wing BJP and the Left Front, neither of which joined the Council of Ministers.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q3. The Second Backward Classes Commission was appointed in 1978 under the chairmanship of Bindeshwari Prasad Mandal (B.P. Mandal). Kaka Kalelkar chaired the First Commission in 1953.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q4. In Indra Sawhney vs Union of India (1992), a 9-judge Supreme Court bench upheld the 27% OBC reservation, capped total quotas at 50%, and mandated the exclusion of the creamy layer.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q5. Inder Kumar Gujral authored the Gujral Doctrine during his tenure as External Affairs Minister and Prime Minister (1997–98), advocating non-reciprocal concessions to neighbours.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q6. The NDA government under Atal Bihari Vajpayee, elected in October 1999 following the Kargil War, governed until May 2004, completing the first non-Congress full five-year term.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q7. Yogendra Yadav identified the Second Democratic Upsurge (1980s–1990s) as the social justice and Mandal mobilisation of Other Backward Classes and Dalits entering power.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q8. The Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA) was enacted in 2005 under UPA-I, providing a statutory guarantee of 100 days of rural wage work.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q9. Following the collapse of the V.P. Singh ministry in November 1990, Chandra Shekhar broke away to form the Samajwadi Janata Party, governing with outside support from Rajiv Gandhi's Congress.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q10. In the 2014 Lok Sabha elections, the BJP won 282 seats on its own (while the NDA won 336 seats), crossing the 272-seat majority mark for the first single-party majority since 1984.

Answer: (B)

Wrong-Answer Clinic — the one-line corrections

If you answered...	Your slip was...	The corrected rule, in one line
Q3 option A	Confusing 1st and 2nd commissions	Kaka Kalelkar chaired the 1st Commission (1953); B.P. Mandal chaired the 2nd Commission (1978).
Q4 option A	Confusing constitutional cases	Kesavananda Bharati established Basic Structure (1973); Indra Sawhney decided OBC quotas (1992).
Q6 option A	Assuming Janata Party lasted 5 years	The Morarji Desai Janata Party government collapsed after 2.5 years in 1979; NDA (1999–2004) was the first to finish 5 years.
Q7 option A	Confusing 1st and 2nd upsurges	The 1st upsurge was adult suffrage (1950s); the 2nd was Mandal/OBC assertion (1980s–90s).
Q10 option C	Using the 2019 tally for 2014	BJP won 282 seats in 2014 and 303 seats in 2019.

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